

DIGITAL ETHICS GUIDELINES Jan-Dec 2026

POLICY GUIDELINES OF DIGITAL ETHICS PROCEDURES

The Digital Ethics Council has formulated certain guidelines for ensuring ethical digital processes and practices in the University. These guidelines are to be followed by all Departments, Sections and offices in the administrative and academic setup of the University, They pertain to all activities on digital platforms.

The guidelines as approved by the competent authority, are as follows:

A) Digital platform based data collection: Online questionnaires, survey based platforms, emails, social media and other online methods are leveraged to collect feedback from target audiences for research purposes. Any public data collection initiative must adhere to the following guidelines:

a) Informed consent:

- i) The purpose and intended usage of the data collected through digital survey must be made clear and transparent.
- ii) Explicit consent of the participants must be obtained at the outset.

b) Anonymization: If the data collected is sensitive and personalized in nature - such as medical history or opinion on policies:

- i) The data may be collected anonymously, or
- ii) Any personally identifiable information (PII) must be stripped off before online storage.
- iii) PII should not be revealed in any research publication.
- iv) The provision for privacy protection must be informed to the participants.

c) Safe storage and transmission: For sensitive applications:

- i) The data must be password protected to allow controlled access to different categories of users.
- ii) The data must be watermarked and encrypted before transmission.

d) Fair Use: The data collected must allow fair use in a manner that:

- i) There is complete protection of individual data

- ii) There is a balance between protection of the interest of the innovator / data owner and future collaborative use of the shared data for future research.

B) Digital and Artificial Intelligence (AI) Ethics: Students and faculty use Generative AI such as Large Language Models (LLM) and Deep Neural Network (DNN) for assignments, assessment, coding etc. The following guidelines must be followed for their ethical usage:

- a) **Citation and Prompts used for LLMs:** Ensure that students;
 - i) Cite the knowledge sources used
 - ii) Share the prompts used for extracting knowledge from LLM/DNN models.
 - iii) Disclose the context in which they have used generative AI, that is when and how AI has been used
- b) **Plagiarism detection:** Students must be informed that their work will be stored into an online database if plagiarism detection software such as Turnitin is used with storage to its database enabled.
- c) **Informed LLM assessment:** If students are being assessed or graded using AI tools, they must be informed.

C) Inclusivity in digital platforms: It is important to be mindful of the potential discrimination in the usage of digital resources and access. To avoid this, the following guidelines should be followed:

- a) Auditing for potential bias:
 - i) In academic work such as admission and examination, the automation tools must be audited to check that there is no bias against a demographic group
 - ii) For research involving data collection for the benefit of people, any bias in the data that may lead to exclusion of specific groups, must be checked and eliminated.
- b) Accessibility alternatives:
 - i) All digital resources for students must comply with the need that students with impairments (visual, auditory or motor skills) are able to use such resources through alternative formats / renditions
 - ii) Such usability considerations should be keyed into procurement for all digital tools.

D) Data Privacy:

- a) Right to know:** The use of any data collected digitally through Learning Management Systems (LMS) such as Google classroom or by independent data collection processes must be transparently shared with the students concerned.
- b) Examination results:** The results of entrance tests, end-semester examinations etc that are shared on public platforms, must be displayed with only identifier numbers such as roll numbers and names should not be displayed.
- c) Limitation and erasure:**
 - i) The limitation of data must be decided at the outset, that is, before collecting data.
 - ii) Sensitive data of students such as any disciplinary action taken against a student during his/her tenure in the University must be erased after completion of his/her degree.
- d) Third party contracts:** If data processing is carried out by any third-party entity:
 - i) Ensure that the data is stored in a secured and its access policy is controlled as per contract and shared with NSUT.
 - ii) Ensure that the data is either transferred back securely or erased, upon termination of services (e.g., Plumsoft or similar service providers).

E) Digital citizenship:

- a) Cyber-bullying:** Cyber bullying on university's digital platform, hate speech or revealing someone's personal information will invite proctoral action. Any such harassment may be reported to the DEC through a declared official email.
- b) Training on digital citizenship:** During orientation and otherwise through workshops, talks etc students, faculty and staff must be trained on issues related to digital safety and ethics.
- c) Reporting for vulnerabilities:** If any person/ entity reports any security flaw(s) and vulnerabilities in the digital ecosystem of the University, then no legal or punitive action will be taken against that person/ entity unless it is accompanied by some illegal or unethical conduct.

II) SCOPE OF FUNCTIONS OF DEC

The DEC shall be mandated to carry out the following activities:

1. Promote ethical digital practices and knowledge dissemination through workshops, conferences, videos and promotional content, lectures in class or otherwise, pedagogical guidelines etc.
2. Approve and vet any project involving digital data collection or processing.
3. Address any reported violation related to digital data safety and data privacy shall be handled and addressed by this committee.
4. Oversee a repository of data collected by the University's personnel and students.
5. Any other related activity as the need arises.
6. The guidelines must be refined as and when the need arises in sync with the current context, by due procedures.



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